“While this scenario was prevalent even when there was only a covert nuclear deterrence . . . overt nuclear capabilities . . . further accentuated this situation.”[63] Proliferation optimists concede that these effects played a central role in facilitating the Kargil operation. Indeed, Ganguly argues that “overt nuclearization . . . bolstered [a] sense of false optimism” among Pakistani leaders. “Pakistani decision-makers had convinced themselves that their achievement of rough nuclear parity with India now enabled them to probe along the LOC with impunity. In their view, the Indian leadership, cognizant of Pakistan’s nuclear capabilities, would decline to use overwhelming force and would also avoid a dramatic escalation or expansion of the conflict.”[64] Elsewhere, Ganguly and Hagerty acknowledge that “absent nuclear weapons, Pakistan probably would not have undertaken the Kargil misadventure in the first place.”[65]

Pakistani political leaders and strategic analysts, as well as optimistic South Asian security scholars, thus recognize nuclear weapons’ emboldening impact on the Pakistanis’ behavior in Kashmir and at Kargil. How, then, do scholars make an optimistic case for nuclear weapons’ role in the Kargil conflict? Optimists argue that although nuclear weapons facilitated Kargil’s outbreak, they also deterred India from crossing the LOC during the fighting, thereby ensuring that the dispute was resolved without resort to full-scale war. Thus Kargil shows that, on balance, nuclear weapons have not destabilized South Asia. Rather, optimists maintain, nuclear weapons’ deterrent effects have prevented conflict escalation and thereby made the region safer.[66] Optimists are correct to argue that Indian leaders’ refusal to cross the line of control prevented escalation of the Kargil conflict. However, Indian policy was not driven primarily by a fear of Pakistani nuclear weapons.

V. P. Malik, Indian Army chief of staff during Kargil, explains that the Indians avoided crossing the line of control mainly out of concern for world opinion. “The political leaders felt that India needed to make its case and get international support” for its position in the conflict. The Indian government believed that it could best do so by exercising restraint even in the face of clear Pakistani provocations.[67] G. Parthasarathy, India’s high commissioner to Pakistan during the Kargil conflict, agrees. Indian leaders refrained from crossing the